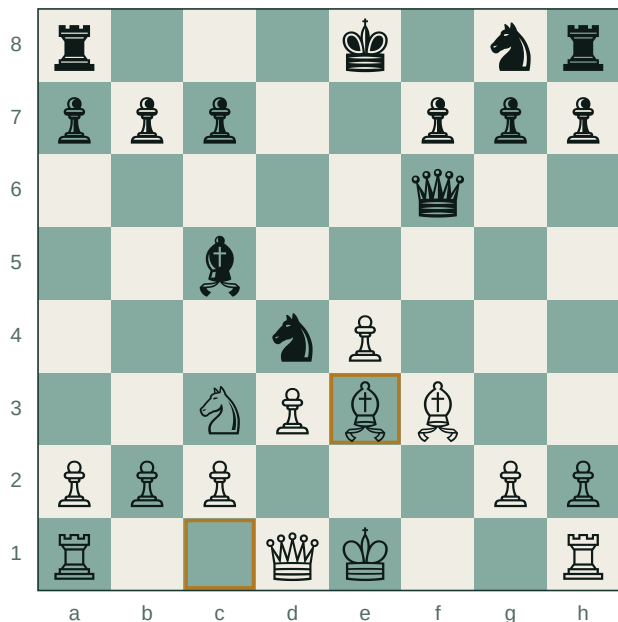


Capture the defender: Black, move 10

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 10.Be3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

10...Nxf3+ 11. Qxf3 Qxf3 12. gxf3 Bxe3 13. Nd5 Bb6

10...Nxf3+ Check restricts White to 5 legal replies here. The changed line means the queen on f6 attacks the knight on c3. Recorded reply: **11.Qxf3**.

11...Qxf3 The queen captures the queen on f3. Recorded reply: **12.gxf3**.

12...Bxe3 The bishop captures the bishop on e3. Recorded reply: **13.Nd5**.

13...Bb6 The bishop moves from e3 to b6.

At the end, nominal material is White 20 / Black 22 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +3:** the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on e1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on e3 and rook on h1. Check for tactical protection.